attempts.[233] A Pakistani journalist, who was well acquainted with several of the group's leaders and mid-level commanders at the time, supports this version of events.[234] David Headley's testimony to investigators also suggests that Lashkar members were at least aware of the plot. He recounts discussing the assassination plan with Abdur Rehman Syed, Haroon and others. Haroon is the army major who, like Syed, took early retirement to join the group. He split from Lashkar in 2003 and later went to work for Ilyas Kashmiri, who was among those arrested for attempting to kill Musharraf, though he later was released for lack of evidence.[235] Notably, Headley stated that Lashkar's operational commander, Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi, knew members of the group had discussed the assassination plot. If true, this would indicate Lashkar's leadership was aware of the plan.[236]

It must be noted that no open source evidence exists to confirm Lashkar's involvement or the participation of any of its members. When asked independently about this lack of public evidence, both the US intelligence officer and the Western diplomat responded almost identically. They each stated that the Pakistani government had the evidence and that they had seen it, but that the government did not allow it to become public because it did not want to have to deal with the repercussions of what that would mean. Notably, the six air force officers along with other military personnel and civilians were tried in a secret court-martial for the two assassination attempts. The number of accused was never made public, though twelve people were found guilty and sentenced to death in 2006.[237]

The Musharraf regime's double game after 9/11 created a situation in which it was cooperating with the US against al-Qaeda while simultaneously supporting militant outfits participating in the jihad against America and its allies. Lashkar was not the only militant group that continued to receive state support, but it was viewed as more reliable and less of a threat to Pakistan than the Deobandi groups, a proposition that proved accurate. In return for keeping a lower profile, Lashkar was granted more freedom of maneuver and allowed to remain more active than other outfits. This enabled the group to build up its martial and social welfare capabilities, and to put itself on the path toward increasing financial independence. It focused the majority of its energies on the Kashmir jihad and on launching or supporting terrorist attacks against India. However, although ordered to